

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Neighbors rally to aid street vendors

Community raises funds to support them amid ICE detentions

By Laura Rodríguez Presa and Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

For nearly 16 years, María Irma Pérez Padilla set up her tamale cart at a busy intersection in Pilsen, selling the beloved Mexican dish to help support her family. The 52-year-old mother worked long days to pay for her diabetes medication and provide for her children after her husband's death two years ago.

Like many older immigrants in the U.S. without legal permission, Pérez relied entirely on street vending to survive. But on a Friday morning in October, masked federal agents in an unmarked vehicle detained her as she prepared an order of tamales. Within minutes, the familiar presence who anchored the corner for more than a decade was gone.

"They were just standing between her and her cart — they didn't even let her finish her job," her son, Jaime Montano, said. Despite having no criminal record, Pérez was taken to a detention center.

She is one of at least 15 vendors immigration authorities have detained from Chicago's streets since the Trump administration launched Operation Midway Blitz in September, according to the Street Vendors Association of Chicago and immigrant rights groups. While the operation was promoted as an effort to target people with violent criminal records who didn't have legal status, the families of detained vendors say most have no such history.

As longtime vendors quietly disappear from the corners they've held for years, community organizations and neighbors are scrambling to support those taken, their families and those still working on the streets. A new local effort has emerged to

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Southside Together member Alajah Wills, center, holds a sign during a chant by tenants and community members in front of the recently raided South Shore apartment building on Monday. The news conference announced formation of the 7500 South Shore Tenants Union. EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

Residents of raided building form union

Those who remain at South Shore apartments press for 'livable' conditions

By Andrew Carter
Chicago Tribune

Almost two months after the militarized raid that roused them from their sleep and made international headlines, those who remain living — or trying to live — at 7500 South Shore Drive gathered Monday morning in the cold outside their deteriorating apartment building in a show of solidarity.

Amid five floors of mostly empty units — some still boarded up from the nighttime immigration raid Sept. 30 — the 36 people who still live there have

united to form the 7500 South Shore Tenants Union. The move to unionize comes after a Cook County judge earlier this month appointed a third-party receiver to manage the property and ordered the building to be vacated.

"The building has been shut down," Infiniti Gant, a housing organizer with Southside Together, said during a news conference while more than 20 residents stood behind her. "So everyone is mandated to get kicked out of the building. What we are hoping for is that while people are preparing to move, they have livable conditions.

Right now, these conditions are not livable, and the owners of the building, the property managers — everyone who's responsible for making sure this building is maintained, would not live like this."

Gant is among those in recent weeks who have helped residents unionize in the aftermath of a late-night raid that was among the most infamous moments in President Donald Trump's Operation Midway Blitz — the monthslong assault on Chicago in which federal agents, including representatives from Immigration and Customs Enforcement and U.S. Border Patrol, have

targeted Latino immigrants.

During the raid at 7500 S. Shore Drive agents dressed for combat rappelled from helicopters onto the building's roof. They broke through windows and stormed inside, where they crashed through doors and placed residents in zip ties and on buses or in the back of box trucks. Many Venezuelan migrants lived in the building and were taken in the raid.

Officials said at the time the operation was meant to target Tren de Aragua gang

Turn to Apartments, Page 5



U.S. Rep. Lauren Underwood and Justin Kidd walk on Beach Street toward reporters after touring the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement holding facility in Broadview on Monday. STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE

Underwood warns immigration crackdown in Chicago is not over

Lawmaker tours Broadview facility, says ICE plans major staff expansion

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Republican President Donald Trump's aggressive immigration enforcement operation in the Chicago area may have ebbed in recent weeks, but U.S. Rep. Lauren Underwood cautioned

Monday against assuming the effort is over after she was granted special access to the federal government's controversial immigration processing center in west suburban Broadview.

Opponents of Operation Midway Blitz, the chaotic and at times violent joint depor-

tation mission carried out by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and Border Patrol, were heartened by this month's departure of controversial Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino. But Underwood, the top Democrat on

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Federal judge tosses Comey, James cases

Rulings conclude interim prosecutor illegally appointed

By Eric Tucker
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — A federal judge dismissed the criminal cases Monday against former FBI Director James Comey and New York Attorney General Letitia James, concluding that the prosecutor who brought the charges at President Donald Trump's urging was illegally appointed by the Justice Department.

The rulings from U.S. District Judge Cameron McGowan Currie halt at least for now a pair of prosecutions that had targeted two of Trump's most high-profile political opponents and amount to a stunning rebuke of the administration's maneuvering to install an inexperienced prosecutor willing to file cases.

The orders do not concern the substance of the allegations against Comey or James but



James Comey, appointed FBI director in 2013, was fired in May 2017 by President Donald Trump. STEPHAN SAVOIA/AP 2017

instead deal with the unconventional manner in which the prosecutor, Lindsey Halligan, was named as interim U.S. attorney for the Eastern District of Virginia. Defense lawyers said the Trump administration had no legal authority to make the

Turn to Cases, Page 11

Investigation into shootings continues

Fourteen-year-old with "vibrant personality" was fatally shot and eight other teens were wounded in downtown Chicago incidents Friday night. **Chicagoland**

Airlines say travel now nearly normal

Travelers flying this week can rest assured that a government shutdown-related national air traffic meltdown has been averted, airlines said. **Business**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 52 Low 34

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 14

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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